

One Signature Move

You don't have ten projects to fill an award-site with. That's fine — most award-sites are thin on content too; what they're actually judged on is **craft in a small number of decisions, executed without a single wrong note**. This guide walks you through building one, in order, with the prompts to hand an AI coding tool at each step.



`cubic-bezier(.16, 1, .3, 1)` — this one curve, used consistently on every hover, reveal and transition in this guide, will do more for "feels premium" than any single effect you add. Inconsistent easing is the fastest way to make a site feel like a template.

How this guide works

Eight phases, in build order. Each ends with an example prompt — copy it into Claude Code, Cursor, or whichever AI coding tool you're using, then look at the result in the browser before moving on. Don't skip ahead: phases 2-3 (foundation, rhythm) are what make phase 4 (the signature move) actually land. A flashy hover effect on an unbalanced grid looks like a demo, not a site.

Work in a local dev environment with hot reload, not by pasting a finished description and hoping. This kind of site is tuned by eye, in small increments — you're the one who decides when the timing "feels right."

PHASE 0 Set up the project

Plain HTML/CSS/JS is enough for a one-pager — don't reach for a framework you don't need. Pull in three libraries: **GSAP** with ScrollTrigger for animation, **Lenis** for smooth scroll, and nothing else until a later phase asks for it.

Stack: `index.html` · `gsap` + `ScrollTrigger` · `lenis` · a local server (`npx serve` or Vite) · deploy target: Vercel or Netlify (free, drag-and-drop or git push).

PROMPT

Set up a static site with `index.html`, `style.css`, `main.js`. Add GSAP + ScrollTrigger and Lenis via CDN. Wire Lenis to drive ScrollTrigger's scroll updates so they stay in sync. No content yet — just a working scaffold I can open with a local server.

PHASE 1 Write the content before designing anything

With little to showcase, the honest move is fewer sections, each one earning its place: a one-line positioning statement (not a job title — a sentence about what you make), two or three pieces of work shown properly instead of six shown thin, a short about paragraph, one contact line. Write the real words now, in a text file — design decisions made against placeholder copy are decisions made against the wrong shapes.

PROMPT

Here's my real content: [paste your positioning line, 2–3 project names with a sentence each on what they were and your role, your about paragraph, contact info]. Turn this into semantic HTML sections — hero, work, about, contact — no styling yet.

PHASE 2 Type and grid, with nothing moving

Pick two typefaces — one with enough personality to carry a headline, one quiet workhorse for body text — set a type scale, and get spacing and alignment right at rest, before any animation exists. This is the phase people rush and it's the one that shows. Judge it with the page sitting still.

PROMPT

Using [typeface A] for display and [typeface B] for body from Google Fonts, style the sections with a clear type scale, a single-column layout up to 680px for text and full-width for the work section, and consistent vertical rhythm. No animation. I want to judge the static page first.

PHASE 3 **Smooth scroll and a reveal rhythm**

Add Lenis-driven smooth scroll, then a single consistent reveal pattern for sections entering the viewport — same distance, same duration, same easing curve every time (use the one above). Resist giving each section a different animation; repetition is what reads as intentional rather than experimental.

PROMPT

Add a ScrollTrigger reveal to each section: `fade in + translateY(24px → 0)`, duration 0.9s, ease `cubic-bezier(.16,1,.3,1)`, triggered once when the section is 20% into the viewport. Stagger child elements (headline, then body, then work items) by 0.08s. Same values everywhere — don't vary them per section.

PHASE 4 Pick the one signature move

This is the phase people over-scope. Choose exactly one from the table below, matched to your time and nerve — not all three. One well-tuned interaction beats three half-finished ones, and it's what everything else on the page is quietly built to set up.

SIGNATURE MOVE — PICK ONE

MOVE	EFFORT	PAYOFF	WHERE IT LIVES
Custom cursor + magnetic buttons	Low (1 evening)	High — touches every page, no risk of looking broken	A styled div tracking the pointer with a short lerp/lag; buttons pull the cursor toward their center on proximity
Split-text hero reveal	Low-Med (1 evening)	Medium-High — makes the first five seconds feel considered	GSAP SplitText (or a free equivalent) animating the headline in on load, once, before anything else
Image hover distortion	High (2-4 days)	High, but fragile — a shader that's slightly off reads as a bug	WebGL via OGL or Three.js, a displacement shader on work-item thumbnails

For a first project with limited content, the cursor + magnetic buttons is the right call: it's forgiving to tune, it's visible on every interaction rather than one hover state, and it fails gracefully — a slightly imperfect cursor still looks intentional, a slightly imperfect shader looks broken.

PROMPT

Build a custom cursor: a small circle that lerps toward the real pointer position (factor ~0.15 per frame via `requestAnimationFrame`), hides the native cursor, and scales to 3x with a `mix-blend-mode` of `difference` when hovering any link or button. Add a magnetic effect to buttons: on `mousemove` within 60px, translate the button up to 12px toward the pointer; reset with a spring ease on `mouseleave`.

PHASE 5 The polish pass

Go through every interactive element — links, buttons, the work items — and check hover, focus, and active states exist and share the same easing curve as everything else. Add an underline animation on text links (width or scale transform, not a color swap). This phase is small individual fixes, not new features; it's most of what separates "nice site" from "award-site."

PROMPT

Audit every link and button for hover, focus-visible, and active states. Add an underline that animates in from the left on link hover (transform: scaleX, not width). Use cubic-bezier(.16,1,.3,1) for every transition on the page — replace any default eases you find.

PHASE 6 Respect the reader

Wrap your animation code in a prefers-reduced-motion check and provide an instant, static fallback. Lazy-load images below the fold, set explicit width/height to avoid layout shift, and run a Lighthouse pass — a slow site undoes an otherwise good one immediately.

PROMPT

Wrap all scroll and cursor animations in a prefers-reduced-motion media query check — when it's set, disable the custom cursor, skip the reveal animations (show content at final state immediately), and keep only essential transitions. Add loading="lazy" and explicit dimensions to all images below the hero.

PHASE 7 Ship it and get real eyes on it

Deploy to Vercel or Netlify — push to a git repo and connect it, or drag the folder into Netlify's dashboard for an instant URL. Then submit or share it somewhere that gives specific feedback rather than general praise; a portfolio site's real test is whether someone unfamiliar with the project understands what you do within ten seconds.

Submit for review	Awwwards, FWA — slow, selective, but the standard
Faster feedback	Siteinspire, Land-book — browsable galleries, less formal
Effect reference	Codrops (Tympanus) — tutorials for most of the interactions above
Library docs	gsap.com/docs, lenis.darkroom.engineering, ogl by oframe (for shaders)

Time budget, realistically

PHASES 0–2 One evening	PHASE 3 One evening	PHASE 4 1–4 days, by move	PHASES 5–7 One weekend
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How to prompt through each phase

Ask for one phase at a time — never "build the whole site with animations." Give the model a value to react to ("the fade is too slow, make it 0.5s") rather than a feeling ("make it punchier") — it can act on a number, not a mood. When something looks close but not right, describe the specific frame that's wrong rather than restarting the prompt. And keep the easing curve, timing values, and spacing scale from earlier phases in view (paste the relevant CSS back in) so later prompts stay consistent with what you already approved.

Built for a portfolio with limited content — the strategy throughout is fewer decisions, made well, over more decisions made adequately.